

mish mode against computer-controlled civilisations can be as tough or as easy as you choose, and finally, the network and online mode offers tremendous entertainment.

The inbuilt scenario editor lets you create your own maps and campaigns, so even after you've finally finished off the single player campaigns, you can always make more of your own—and make them as easy or difficult as you like.

The game is a little simplified compared to older versions—you don't need to build storage structures next to your workforce that is gathering wood and minerals. This decreases the amount of detailed management required by a player, and lets you get right into the game's entertainment—attacking and defending!

Overall, the game isn't too different from the *Age Of Empires II* (*Age Of Kings*), which is both good and bad. The good part is that players have virtually no learning curve, and the bad part is that *AOE3* is the successor to one of the most popular strategy games of all time—a little disappointing in terms of innovation. Basically, we were perhaps expecting a little too much from *AOE3*!

Rise Of Nations

In 2003, a company called Big Huge Games rolled out a game called *Rise Of Nations* (RON). At first glance, it's easy to mistake RON for *Age Of Empires*, and that's what most people thought it was at first—some sort of expansion pack for *AOE*. The difference became apparent when you started playing the game!

Unlike in *AOE*, here you start with a city and a national border. What's that, you ask? Exactly! See the difference? Basically, each city you build is isolated from another city, and you can only build city structures within each city's clearly demarcated national border. There are also limits to the number of buildings you can build within each city limits. This forces players to build quickly and then expand to another city.